

Ten Years of SAP, and What Odoo Taught Me in a Week

A short account of the journey behind this pitch — and the dozens of passes it actually took — for whoever's curious after the meeting

Waqas Abbas Mian · Senior ERP Solution Architect

I want to leave you with something shorter and more personal than the package itself — not another proof point, but the honest account of how I got here, including the part that doesn't show up in a polished PDF: how many times this was wrong before it was right, and whose judgement caught it each time.

What the iterations actually looked like

This package did not arrive in one pass. It went through dozens of rounds — a live build, then an audit of that build, then a peer review of the audit, then a live regression test of the peer review's own findings, each round stricter than the last — because I directed it that way, not because a tool volunteered the rigour. I used AI tooling throughout, and I want to be specific about the shape of that collaboration rather than wave at it: the tool moved fast and held detail I couldn't hold in my head across fifteen cross-referenced documents and a live system at once; I supplied the standard it had to clear, and I was the one who kept sending work back. A few of those redirects are worth naming, because they show the direction travelling one way and the platform knowledge travelling the other: when the first screenshots of the demo came back looking like generic SaaS rather than Odoo, I sent them back to study the actual product before touching the render again. When a written review of my own work claimed a set of "critical defects," I didn't accept the write-up — I had it log back into the live system and verify every claim against reality, which found that some were real and had to be fixed, and others were simply false. When the package's language didn't match a German client and a UK hiring panel, I corrected the convention rather than let a plausible-sounding default stand. None of that judgement came from the tool. It came from a decade of sitting in the room when a client asks the question a document didn't anticipate, and knowing which answer survives that room.

Where the discipline came from

I never studied computer science. I built my way into enterprise software from the ground up — running a Shell forecourt through college, running a warehouse's WMS and its returns queue by hand, teaching myself SQL to keep an e-commerce site alive — and then ten years inside the SAP ecosystem: C4/HANA, Hybris, Cloud for Customer, Sales and Service Cloud, most recently CRM architecture at enterprise scale. What that decade actually taught me wasn't a product. It was a **lifecycle** — blueprint, workshop, functional spec, build, UAT, hypercare — and a rule that survives any platform: nothing you show a client is real until you've tried to break it yourself first. That rule is the reason this package went through as many rounds as it did.

What this case study actually taught me about Odoo

I had never configured Odoo before this brief. What I found, learning it under deadline, surprised me: it isn't a lesser SAP — it's a different bet entirely. SAP separates and specialises; Odoo unifies one data model and lets automation rules carry the compliance logic that SAP would spread across modules and middleware. For a mid-market regulated manufacturer, that unification is the whole value proposition — I could direct the build of a real GxP-aware compliant thread, four enforced controls, and full UDI traceability in days, on a platform that costs a fraction of the enterprise suites I spent a decade implementing. That's not a knock on SAP; it's a precise answer to *which client needs which tool*, which is the question a decade of SAP work actually trains you to ask — and the knowledge transfer ran both ways here: the tooling taught me Odoo's mechanics fast enough to direct a real build under deadline; my decade of delivery taught it what "done" actually means before a client sees it.

What I learned about much.

I read your MedTech page closely enough to notice what it doesn't yet say about the UK's 2025–26 device reforms, and I found your Managing Partner's own conference talk before I ever met anyone from your team — not to flatter it back to you, but because understanding a firm's actual published thinking is the same discovery discipline I'd bring to a client engagement. What came through in that research, and in the case brief itself, is a business that would rather say "here's what we don't know yet" than oversell a capability — which is exactly the instinct this whole package was built around, redirect by redirect. That's not a coincidence I'm pointing out to flatter you; it's the reason I think I'd fit here without having to unlearn anything.

THE HONEST SUMMARY

I didn't come into this case study as an Odoo expert, and I'm not going to pretend otherwise. I came in as someone who has spent a decade learning that the platform is never really the hard part — the discipline is, and the discipline is what you apply round after round until the work survives contact with someone trying to break it. That's what these weeks actually were: not one clever build, but a long argument between what a tool produced and what my experience would accept — repeated until they agreed. That's what I'd bring to your team on day one, on whichever platform your next client happens to be running.